

Deserts

Deserts are the driest habitats on Earth, with less than 25 cm (10 in) of rainfall a year. They may be hot, cold, or coastal, depending on their geographic position, but all are dry. Desert animals and plants must be able to survive with little or no water and endure significant daily ranges in temperature.

WHERE IN THE WORLD?

The biggest deserts are in the hot, dry parts of north Africa, Arabia, and Australia. Other deserts have formed in Asia and the Americas, in places that are far from oceans, or cut off by mountain ranges.



TYPES OF DESERTS

All deserts share one feature – they are very dry. But they form in many ways, and each desert is different. Many are sandy, others are rocky, and a few are snowy. Some are not as dry as others, and have a lot of plant life.



HOT DESERT

In deserts such as the Sahara, heat makes any moisture dry up. These deserts are hot by day and cold by night. They can be sandy or stony.



COLD DESERT

Cold deserts are far from oceans. They are much cooler than hot deserts, with short summers and heavy snowfall in the winter.



COASTAL DESERT

Where deserts occur by the sea they may be covered in fog but still go for years without rainfall, remaining very dry.

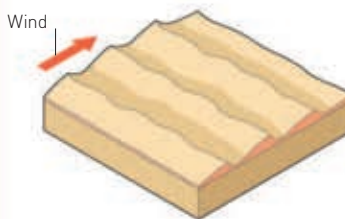
SAND DUNES

The desert wind can blow dry sand into heaps called dunes. When the wind loses strength, it drops the sand suspended in it. The shape the resulting dunes form depends on wind direction and sand texture.



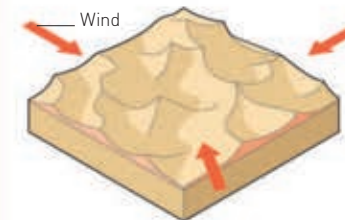
CRESCENT DUNES

These dunes have less sand at their edges, meaning those parts of the dune move faster, giving a distinctive crescent shape.



TRANSVERSE DUNES

Constant winds form long ridges of sand that look like waves on the sea. The crests lie across the direction of the wind.



STAR DUNES

Where the wind blows from different directions, it heaps up sand in irregular shapes. These dunes can grow very big.

MAMMALS

Most desert mammals are small animals that hide in burrows during the day to avoid the heat. Larger mammals such as camels are adapted to withstand the heat and retain water.



REPTILES

The scaly, waterproof bodies of lizards and other reptiles stop them drying out under the desert sun. Many snakes have a venomous bite, so that they can kill prey quickly without using too much energy.



PLANTS

Most desert plants have very deep or wide-spreading roots to gather water – some have both. Cactus plants, euphorbias, and others have spongy stems that store water. Other plants survive as seeds, which sprout after rare rainfall.

